

Phil 170 - Problems in Social Thought (4 credits Gen Ed (SB))
Social Problems in Science
TuTh 10:00AM - 11:15AM
Mary Lyon 119

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Course Overview

Course Description: This course is a survey of social problems in the philosophy of science. Our main focus will be on *values* and *objectivity* in science. We will cover topics such as: (i) the value-free ideal of science, (ii) the role of non-epistemic values in science, (iii) the sociality of science, (iv) objectivity as an ideal, (v) values and objectivity in the social sciences, (vi) feminist philosophy of science, and (vii) socially responsible science and big data.

This course also serves as a general introduction to philosophy. Through class participation and coursework students will develop their skills in reading comprehension, critical thinking, and philosophical writing.

We will read and discuss difficult and (at times) deeply felt social and political problems in this course. As such, not only are critical thinking and good communication skills enormously important, but so too is respect for all persons in this class.

This course also meets the goals of the General Education Social and Behavioural Sciences designation.

Course Objectives: The student learning objectives of this course are the following. The first is to introduce students to problems and important works in the philosophy of science and the philosophy of social science. The second is to develop the philosophical skills and the intellectual and interpersonal tools necessary in approaching philosophical debates.

Assignments/Grades

Attendance	5%
Participation	10%
Short Writing Assignments (1-2 pg, double-spaced)	30% (4.28% each; 7 total)
Mini Paper 1 (4-6 pgs, double-spaced)	15%
Mini Paper 2 (4-6 pgs, double-spaced)	15%
Final Exam (in-class exam)	25%

Grading Scale	
A	92.6+ %

A-	90-92.5%
B+	87.6-89.9%
B	82.6-87.5%
B-	80-82.5%
C+	77.6-79.9%
C	72.6-77.5%
C-	70-72.5%
D+	67.6-69.9%
D	60-67.5%
F	<59.9%

Attendance (5%): You are expected to be present in all 26 class sessions. You can miss up to two (2) classes without it affecting your attendance grade. Life happens!

Excused absences include verifiable health-related incapacities, family illnesses or deaths, jury duty, military obligations, scheduled activities for other classes, and recognized religious observances. Students are expected to communicate with instructors promptly, and professors may request written documentation or doctor's notes. (<https://www.umass.edu/registrar/academic-regulations>)

How it is graded: You can miss up to two (2) classes without it affecting your attendance grade, after that you will lose 5% of your attendance grade for every unexcused absence.

Late arrivals: A student showing up 5 minutes after class starts is counted as "tardy". Three tardies equals one unexcused absence.

Being in class and participating is vital for a philosophy course. While points disappear on an accelerated scale, if you are experiencing a documented long-term medical or personal emergency, please contact me as soon as possible and we can make an alternative arrangement.

Participation (10%): You are expected to show engagement with the class and to participate in in-class assignments. Class engagement involves actively listening, reading aloud, and asking or answering questions. There will be several in-class assignment modules including small group work, group discussions, and two large-scale debates.

How it is graded: Class engagement is worth 5% of this grade. You do not need to talk every day to get full points; your participation will be graded in terms of consistency and quality over the course of the semester. In-class assignment participation is worth 5% of this grade.

Short Writing Assignments (30%): You will have seven short writing assignments during the course of the semester. These assignments are short (typically ~1-2 pages of writing). The assignments will cover (i) **argument comprehension** and (ii) **writing and feedback practice**. I will post **instructions and rubrics** for each assignment at the beginning of the week on which it is due. I will give brief comments on writing assignments. **Assignments are due on Canvas on Sundays by 6:00pm EST (see schedule).**

Mini Papers (30%): You will write **two position papers** over the course of the semester. Papers are 4-6 pgs. double spaced (standard format). I will post prompts and the requirements/rubrics for each paper one week prior to the due date. I will give detailed comments on papers. [You will receive anonymous objections from a fellow classmate on your papers (assignments #4 & 6) and have to write a memo response briefly responding to the objections (assignments #5 & 7).] **Papers are due on Canvas on Sundays by 6:00pm EST (see schedule).**

Final Exam (25%): During finals week, there will be an **in-class final exam**. This exam will be comprehensive; it will involve short answer questions on the readings covered in the class and a short essay.

Late Work: I will accept late work up to one week late. Each day late will incur a penalty of 4% of the total grade of the assignment. Late work resulting from documented emergencies or accommodations will be handled on a case-by-case basis.

Additional Information

Course Materials: *All readings are available on Canvas.* If you get alternative copies, make sure they are the **same editions** as those available on Canvas.

Office Hours: I have office hours Wednesdays from 12:30 - 1:30 or *by appointment* (also meeting on Zoom is fine).

Communication: If you need to contact me outside of office hours, you can reach me by email. You must use your UMass email when emailing me. During the week, I will respond to emails within 24 hours and try to reply to emails sent during business hours the same day. If you send me an email outside of business hours, do not expect a same-day response.

Accommodation: If you find the course in any way inaccessible, please let me know. If you need academic accommodation, please contact [Disability Services](#). The University of Massachusetts Amherst is committed to making reasonable, effective, and appropriate accommodations to meet the needs of students with disabilities and help create a barrier-free campus. If you have a disability and require accommodations, please register with Disability Services, meet with an Access Coordinator in Disability Services, and send your accommodation letter to your faculty. Information on services and registration is available on the Disability Services website (<https://www.umass.edu/disability/>)

Academic Honesty: UMass Amherst is strongly committed to academic integrity, which is defined as completing all academic work without cheating, lying, stealing, or receiving unauthorized assistance from any other person, or using any source of information not appropriately authorized or attributed. As a community, we hold each other accountable and support each other's knowledge and understanding of academic integrity. Academic dishonesty is prohibited in all programs of the University and includes but is not limited to: Cheating, fabrication, plagiarism, lying, and facilitating dishonesty, via analogue and digital means (**including the use of AI in any form**). Sanctions may be imposed on any student who has committed or participated in an academic integrity infraction. Any person who has reason to believe that a

student has committed an academic integrity infraction should bring such information to the attention of the appropriate course instructor as soon as possible. All students at the University of Massachusetts Amherst have read and acknowledged the Commitment to Academic Integrity and are knowingly responsible for completing all work with integrity and in accordance with the policy: <https://www.umass.edu/studentsuccess/academic-honesty>.

Title IX Policy: In accordance with Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 that prohibits gender-based discrimination in educational settings that receive federal funds, the University of Massachusetts Amherst is committed to providing a safe learning environment for all students, free from all forms of discrimination, including sexual assault, sexual harassment, domestic violence, dating violence, stalking, and retaliation. This includes interactions in person or online through digital platforms and social media. Title IX also protects against discrimination on the basis of pregnancy, childbirth, false pregnancy, miscarriage, abortion, or related conditions, including recovery. There are resources here on campus to support you. A summary of the available Title IX resources (confidential and non-confidential) can be found at the following link: <https://www.umass.edu/titleix/resources>. You do not need to make a formal report to access them. If you need immediate support, you are not alone. Free and confidential support is available 24 hours a day / 7 days a week / 365 days a year at the SASA Hotline 413-545-0800.

RAP Goals Statement: This course is a Residential Academic Program (RAP) course. It is equivalent to content, credit, and workload to the course section taught on main campus. The Fall 2026 Instructor Syllabus Information advantage is that this course assists in your smooth transition to college life by providing you the opportunity to develop early connections with your instructor and peers. Through this course, you will learn about resources, campus opportunities for involvement and success, and develop skills to achieve your goals.

***Note: The syllabus/schedule is subject to change at the discretion of the instructor.**

Readings and Assignments Schedule

***Note:** if there are no sections/pages listed, the entire article/chapter is assigned.

Week 1: Value-Free Ideal of Science

Sep 8	syllabus day
Sep 10	Reichenbach, <i>Experience and Prediction</i> (pp. 3-8) Chalmers, <i>Science and Its Fabrication</i> (pp. 91-95)

Week 2-3: Values in Science

Sep 15	Elliott, <i>A Tapestry of Values: An Introduction to Values in Science</i> (selections)
Sep 17	(continued)
Sep 20	<i>Assignment #1 due</i>

Sep 22	Douglas, “Rejecting the Ideal of Value-Free Science” in <i>Value-Free Science: Ideals and Illusions?</i>
Sep 24	(continued)
Sep 27	<i>Assignment #2 due</i>

Week 4-5: Science and Democracy

Sep 29	Kitcher, <i>Science, Truth, and Democracy</i> (Ch. 6)
Oct 1	(continued)
Oct 4	<i>Assignment #3 due</i>
Oct 6	Kitcher, <i>Science, Truth, and Democracy</i> (Ch. 7)
Oct 8	Kitcher, <i>Science, Truth, and Democracy</i> (Ch. 10)

Week 6: Workshops and Mini-Paper #1

Oct 13	(continue Kitcher Ch. 10) + <i>Writing Workshop</i>
Oct 15	<i>Debate #1</i>
Oct 18	<i>Mini-Paper #1 due</i>

Week 7-8: Objectivity as an Ideal

Oct 20	Daston and Galison, “The image of objectivity”
Oct 22	(continued)
Oct 25	<i>Assignment #4 due</i>
Oct 27	(continue Daston and Galison)
Oct 29	Montuschi, “Scientific Objectivity” in <i>Philosophy of Social Science: A New Introduction</i> .
Nov 1	<i>Assignment #5 due</i>

Week 9-10: Values/Objectivity in Social Sciences

Nov 3	Election Day: No Class
Nov 5	(continue Montuschi)
Nov 10	Kincaid, “Live empirical issues in debates over objectivity in the social sciences”
Nov 12	(continued)
Nov 15	<i>Mini-Paper #2 due</i>

Week 11-12: Feminist Philosophy of Science

Nov 17	Kourany, <i>Philosophy of Science after Feminism</i> (Ch. 1)
Nov 19	(continued)
Nov 22	<i>Assignment #6 due</i>

Thanksgiving Break: No Class

Dec 1	Wylie and Hankinson Nelson, “Coming to Terms with the Values of Science: Insights from Feminist Science Studies Scholarship” in <i>Value-Free Science: Ideals and Illusions?</i>
Dec 3	(continued)
Dec 6	<i>Assignment #7 due</i>

Week 13: Socially Responsible Science and Big Data

Dec 8	Mittelstadt et al. “The ethics of algorithms: mapping the debate”
Dec 10	<i>Debate #2</i>

Week 14: Final Exam

Dec 15	Final Exam (in class)
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